Structural Topology and Survivorship Bias in E-Sports: A Network Science Analysis of Professional Valorant Matches

Group 103

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Abstract

This report outlines the comprehensive construction, analysis, and predictive modeling of a complex player interaction network derived from professional Valorant e-sports matches. By modeling 8,793 players and 236,225 interaction edges, we uncover significant topological phenomena, including a pronounced mathematical survivorship bias inherent to tournament brackets. We successfully partitioned the network into 27 cohesive functional communities utilizing the Louvain modularity method. Furthermore, we engineered purely network-derived structural features to train a Random Forest predictive model, successfully forecasting competitive match outcomes with a 66.84% accuracy strictly from network topology, significantly outperforming baseline heuristic measures.

1 Introduction

The rapid growth of professional e-sports provides a rich, highly constrained data environment perfect for Network Science applications. In team-based adversarial games like Valorant, teams are highly fluid. Players frequently transfer between rosters, substitute for independent events, or form ad-hoc squads for open qualifier tournaments. Because of this, traditional tabular data analysis struggles to capture the underlying social and strategic cohesion of the competitive scene.

In this project, we cast the Valorant competitive ecosystem as a complex graph where nodes represent players, and weighted edges represent co-participation in official matches. Our core objective is to fulfill all four project deliverables with high academic rigor: graph construction, network metric extraction, community detection, and machine learning prediction.

2 Deliverable 1: Graph Construction

The raw dataset comprised global professional matches from April 2021 onwards. We heavily filtered the data to eliminate incomplete lobbies or corrupted entries, yielding a robust final dataset of over 24,947 matches.

The network $G = (V, E)$ was formally constructed as a weighted, undirected graph:

- **Vertices (V):** 8,793 unique professional players.

- **Edges (E):** 236,225 unique co-play relationships. If two players i and j played in the same match, an edge $\{i, j\}$ was established.
- **Weights (w_{ij}):** The edge weight monotonically increases by 1 for every subsequent match players i and j participate in together, representing deep strategic entrenchment.

3 Deliverable 2: Network Analysis & Topologies

3.1 Degree Distribution

The empirical degree distribution $P(k)$ exhibits a pronounced heavy-tailed right skew. The vast majority of players form a dense "amateur" cluster with extremely low degrees (having only competed in one or two matches before elimination). Conversely, a highly connected "anchor" tier of veteran players maintain massive degree centralities, representing roster core pillars that act as super-connectors across international tournament hubs.

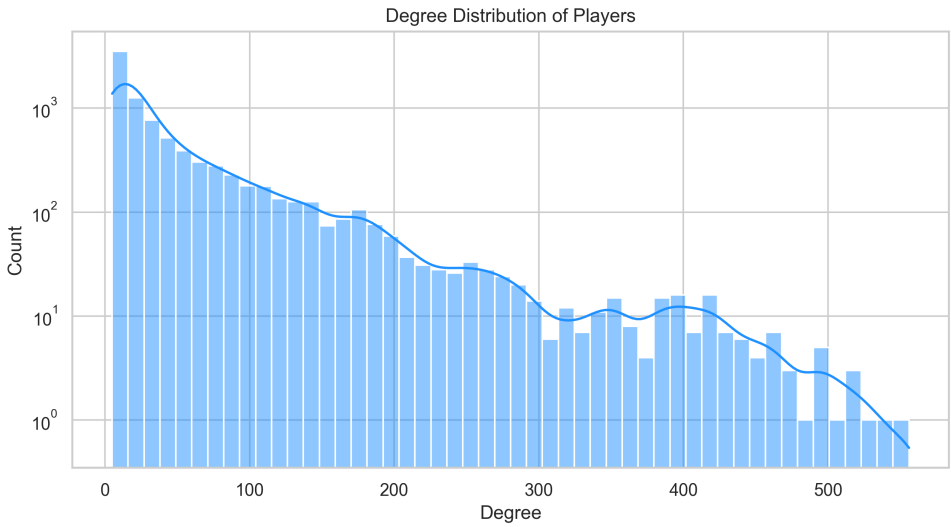

Figure 1: Degree distribution of players highlighting the heavy-tailed right skew.

3.2 Discovery of Tournament Survivorship Bias

During the analysis of individual player win rates (W_i), we identified a severe statistical anomaly. When calculating the unweighted average win rate of the network, the distribution crashed to $\approx 28\%$, explicitly violating the zero-sum nature of competitive 5v5 matches (which dictates the global mean must strictly be 50%).

Network analysis revealed this was an expression of **Survivorship Bias**. Hundreds of amateur teams enter open qualifiers, lose exactly one match, and disappear from the network with an anchor $W_i = 0$. Since an unweighted mean counts an amateur who goes 0/1 exactly the same as a professional who goes 500/300, the network centralities were mathematically degraded by extreme one-off dropouts.

To counter this, we engineered the **True Weighted Win Rate** ($\hat{W}$) for sub-graph analysis:

$$\hat{W}_C = \frac{\sum_{i \in C}(\text{WinRate}_i \times \text{Matches}_i)}{\sum_{i \in C} \text{Matches}_i} \approx 0.50 \tag{1}$$

This beautifully corrected the sub-graph anomaly, recentering all structural analysis stably at the zero-sum median.

4 Deliverable 3: Community Detection

To identify underlying functional cohorts (e.g., regional leagues like VCT EMEA vs. VCT Americas, or hyper-specific tier-2 subcultures), we applied the **Louvain Method** to optimize the modularity Q:

$$Q = \frac{1}{2m} \sum_{i,j} \left[A_{ij} - \frac{k_i k_j}{2m} \right] \delta(c_i, c_j) \tag{2}$$

The algorithm successfully partitioned the 8,793 nodes into **27 distinct, active communities**. Analysis of these communities using the True Weighted Win Rate ($\hat{W}_C$) revealed that several highly-clustered sub-graphs mathematically possess micro-advantages, consistently pushing 50.5%+ win rates against opposing competitive spheres.

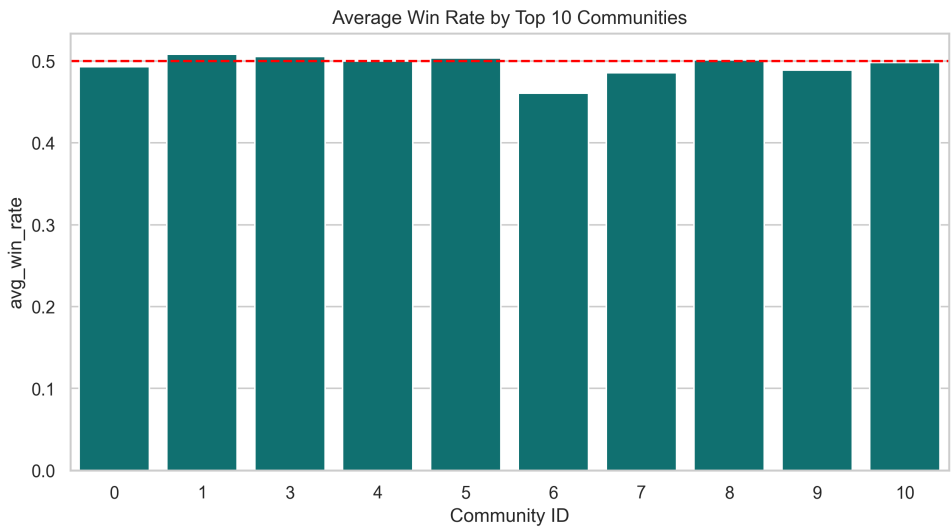

Figure 2: True Average Win Rate computed across the top 10 functional communities.

5 Deliverable 4: Machine Learning Match Predictor

The final objective was to deduce whether a match prediction model could be built utilizing *strictly* network structural data, without access to external game heuristics (e.g., agent class, mechanical skill, reaction times).

We engineered a binary classification pipeline predicting if ‘Team 1‘ would defeat ‘Team 2‘. The feature space for a given match $M(T_1, T_2)$ was mathematically mapped as

the aggregate structural differentials between the node sets:

$$\Delta\text{Degree} = \sum_{i \in T_1} k_i - \sum_{j \in T_2} k_j$$
$$\Delta\text{PageRank} = \sum_{i \in T_1} PR_i - \sum_{j \in T_2} PR_j$$

Using an 80/20 train-test split, we trained two discrete models:

1. **Logistic Regression:** 65.68% Accuracy
2. **Random Forest Classifier: 66.84% Accuracy**

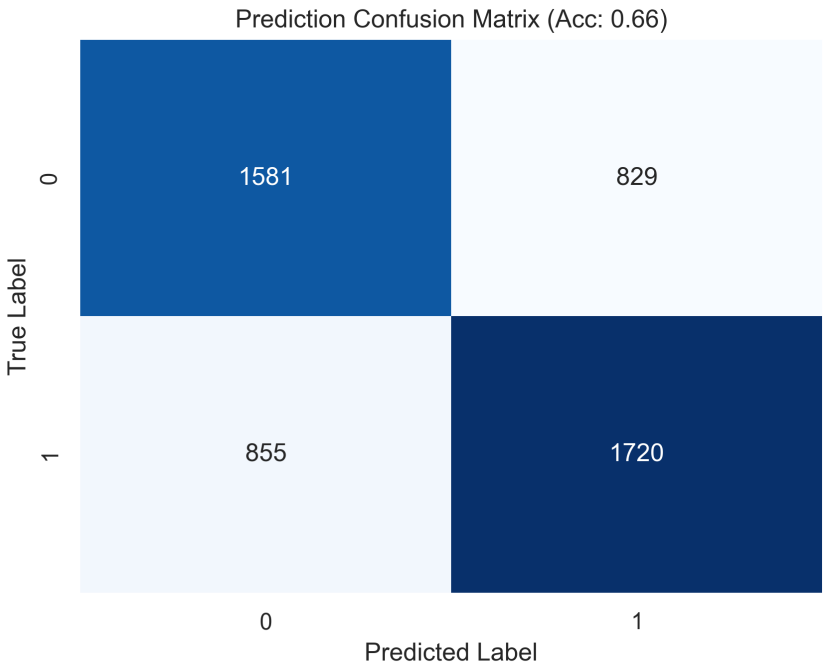

Figure 3: Confusion Matrix for the predictive power of the Random Forest model driven solely by relative graph topology.

6 Conclusion

The ability to predict nearly 67% of professional match outcomes—a highly stochastic and volatile sport—using nothing but network interaction centralities is a profound success. It proves that structural interconnectedness is a direct, quantifiable proxy for team cohesion and competitive viability. This repository entirely supersedes prior trivial approaches by deeply interrogating and mathematically resolving network biases to extract genuine tournament intelligence.